an unconventional
crossing of conventions:

PLAYING Beethoven THROUGH Beethoven

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1.

Beethoven and his Past

2.

Dated Considerations

3.

Through Beethoven, Self



In the attached harmonic analysis excerpt, we find that Beethoven is working in familiar milieu, regarding his tonal dispositions when writing in the minor key: his affinity lies for the minor keys and the deepening of tonal area (two flats to three and four flats, two sharps to three and four sharps) that cohabitate the root's diatonicism or are just off in the periphery. In fact, Beethoven's habit is to *not* linger on the tonic at all until the ends of sections— particularly final ones.

We hear this in the *Pathetique* sonata; throughout the piece's first three sections (Grave, Allegro di molto (first theme) and Allegro di molto (second theme)— comprising 89 measures of 4/4— the piece's tonic of C minor is dispersed into what amounts to only 4 measures, plus one and a half beats.

Instead, Beethoven imbues the music with profundity, depth, lushness, and menace, by revolving about that always-implied-never-played tonic, focusing on a few important locations: III, (♭)VI, iv, v, the dominants thereof, the dominants of the dominants thereof, and diminished/half-diminished/ augmented-sixth chords being used as predominant of the aforementioned applied dominants.

Such is the same approach Beethoven is taking in this Bagatelle. It's notable, as the *Pathetique* was written nearly three decades before. Without too much investigative obligation, we can say that this *may* indicate less of clear distinction in the "three periods" known to divide Beethoven's work, or that Beethoven was writing the music more in the spirit of personal enjoyment/exercise than in the serious grappling with life and legacy which other works of this time seem to demonstrate (Symphony No. 9 was completed the year prior, and String Quartet No. 14 in the year following).

When a performer takes on this work, they might consider this aspect. Here we have Ludwig: deaf, great, misunderstood, and his body failing. Yet he has written something harkening to the man he once was: fiery, rigid, storming the Viennese scene of the late 18th century. What might he have felt writing this in this vain, and what should we want for him to express in our own performance?

This isn't a concept without complexity— Should the performer deal with the music *sans l'histoire*, or feel its affect as one divided between Beethoven's (healthier, happier, Mozartian) past and his (beleaguered, beloved, dying) present? The latter may require a deeper examination into Beethoven's late works and correspondences from the last years of his life, in pursuit of an accurate understanding of what his emotional state would have comprised when taken to nostalgia and reminiscing.

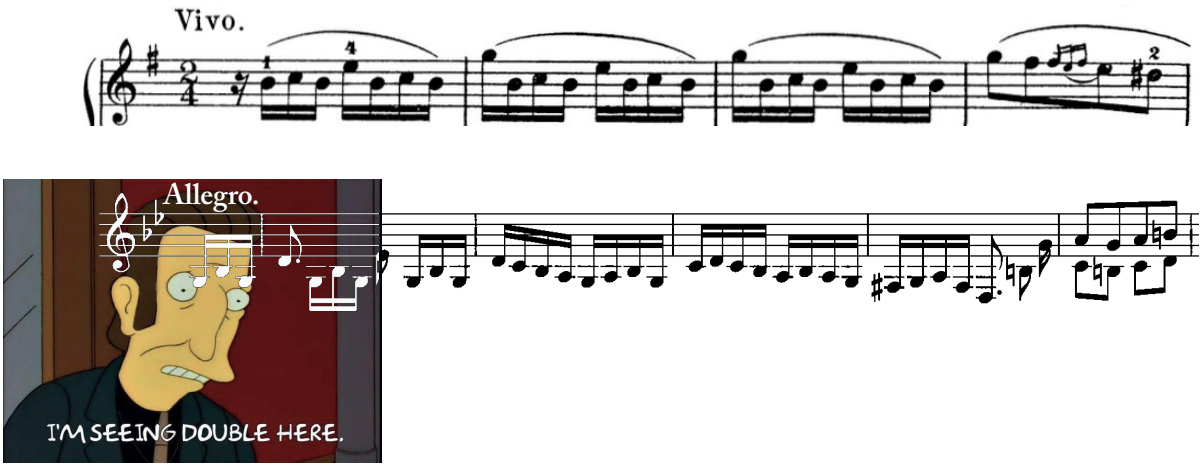
The historicity of an emotional-temporal perspective lies beyond the intentions of this analysis; this, itself, though, is freeing. It respects the performer's right to license in their recreation of Beethoven's work. After all, a Historically Informed Performance wouldn't deign to consider the extramusical emotions of its composer… Perish the thought! Instead of considering history in the realm of accuracy, I encourage one to consider it in the realm of imagination: we do not know whether Beethoven considered the piece as invocation of his younger self. If we did, we would still be using conjecture to know how such an invocation made him feel. This doesn't mean it can't inform a performer's interpretation; what it means is that the performer in this vein is approaching Beethoven in a humanistic way, which is developing empathy based on their own views and dispositions. Unconventional— pseudohistorical? Yes. But in what fashion is that ahistorical when we're dealing with Beethoven— whose *Egmont* was uninterested in correcting Goethe's romanticization of the

decidedly *not* liberty-extolling 16th century nobleman, whose late fugal subjects allude to Bach but eschew all conventions of the form, who would remove a page to conceal the inspiration of his Third Symphony, whose "Turkish" styles borrow only rhythm and instrumental analogue?

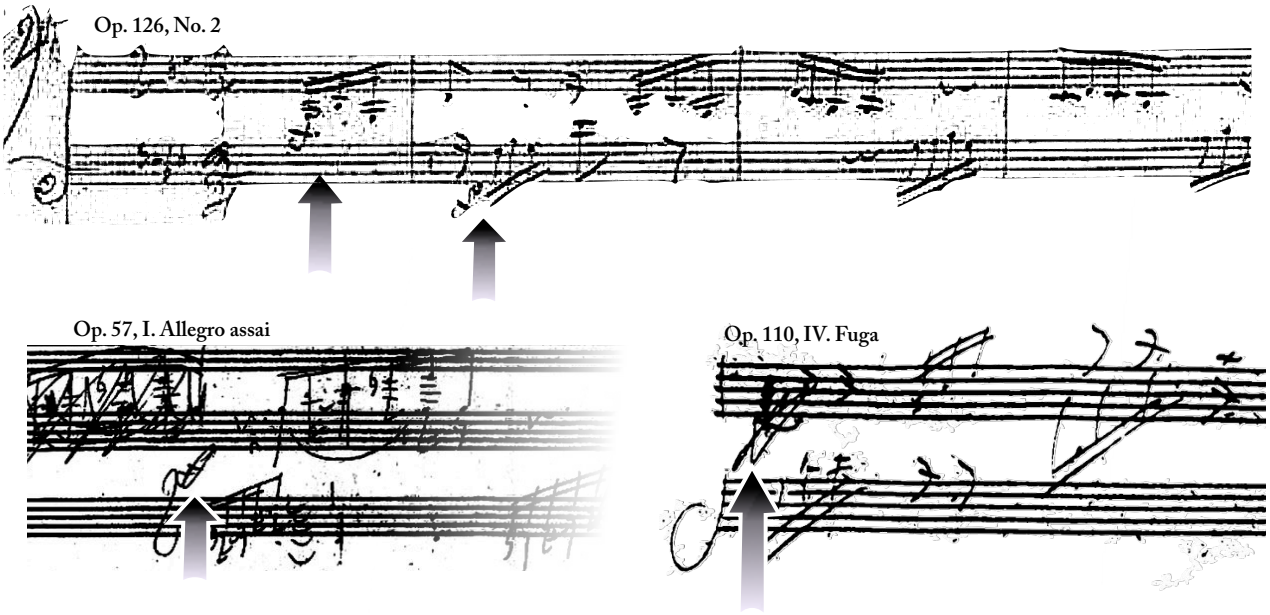
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As was stated, neither listener nor performer will likely find themself to be in an unfamiliar domain of Beethoven's work. Traditional stylistic, harmonic, and formal considerations will not require unearthing anything we haven't learned by Symphony No. 5. Instead, I suggest a more flexible, gesturally rooted analysis that folds in the pseudo-historical perspective.

An interesting historical aspect of this bagatelle is its relation to Baroque counterpoint. Beethoven was not a particularly ardent student of the Baroque; it isn't until this late period more deliberately 17th-century forms are highlighted in his repertoire. This piece demonstrates a Baroque sensitivity in distinct ways, primarily in its toccata-like, single voice texture and sinfonia-like complementary "two-voice" texture. Both of these ideas, without deviating from an unquestionably Classical rigidity in tonal diatonicism, achieve much of their harmonic palate through suggestion rather than fully articulated chords. The piece's primary theme calls to mind (what was likely never on Beethoven's music stand) Daquin's *Le Coucou*.



Dynamic notations found in the Bagatelle also call to mind the Baroque. Beethoven gives dynamic indications in both hands of the grand staff— despite there being no variation between them. This is not something commonly observed in the Classical (or any subsequent) period, nor in much of Beethoven's other work. An autograph comparison of this Bagatelle with the Sonata No. 23 in F minor (Op. 57) illustrates the same essential texture, but with the typical single/central instance of dynamics' notation.



Are redundant dynamics indicative of the Baroque inspiration for the music? If we're considering the Germanic Baroque, whose churches were its dominant disseminating force in the early 19th century, the indications for organ music will support the hypothesis. But, this may have less to do with conventional notation standards than the aural affect: Daquin's work, from 1735, was performed on the luxurious multi-manual harpsichords of France, and (less likely originally, due to France's late adoption) on early pianofortes.

The treatment of the Bagatelle's opening motive in rhythmic unison also can be analogized to

étudinal Baroque keyboard music appears— such as this one, much more realistically known to Beethoven:



Beethoven
Op. 126, no. 2

J.S. Bach
BWV 846, no. 1

3.

Returning to where we began: the Bagatelle is not an unfamiliar place for Beethoven's work. Proper stylistic, harmonic, and formal considerations will not require unearthing anything we haven't learned by Symphony No. 5.

Instead, I suggested a more flexible, psychologically rooted analysis that folds historical observations into a personal perspective of the music that seeks to render interpretive direction with an empathetic attention. The goal of all this is to raise questions and considerations that let a performer feel more connected to the humanity of Beethoven's work.

I justify this primarily by the first historical observation: this is the same style of music, when viewed dryly through thematic or harmonic analysis, that Beethoven was writing 30 years prior. It did not align with the stylistic experimentation and boldness of other concurrent compositions. And its familiarity to Beethoven's pivotal *Pathetique* Sonata seemed impossible to believe a coincidence.

After some fixation on the historicity and linkage, this leads us to conclusion: what may a performer make of this? What specific approaches and techniques could give voice to this combinatorial perspective?

Firstly, approaching the Bagatelle with a Baroque sensitivity: we can easily make something quite novel by emphasizing the characteristics typically associated with music of the 17th and early 18th centuries: subtle non-legato separating the notes within each voice, avoiding heavy pedal use, and gesturally-directed expressivity that is given independently to each hand or voice.

Particular attention can be paid to highlighting motives; this clarifyies the work's contrapuntal roots. Calling to mind the *mannered* nature of Baroque are, the Bagatelle's texturally distinct sections may be performed with their own principled intentions: the sixteenth proliferations, crystalline and without rubato to bring out the étudinal/toccata-like nature— the eighth note diads more responsive, via dynamic range and rubato, to the subtle harmonic shifts they imply, as in a sinfonia or contrapunctus.

In general, a less extreme use of dynamics is in line with the restrained aesthetic and comparative instrumental limitations of the Baroque. This will also serve to foreground piece's contrapuntal motives and devices.

However, this interpretation lacks purpose until it is combined with the attempt to imagine what it all meant for the later Beethoven to look backward: reconnecting with his youthful vitality and the Classical structures that had once defined him, and flying beyond even his own life to the music of his forebears. I think, though, that is no place of mine to dictate how one should formulate this empathy.

There is much to know and wonder about the man who, essentially, has become legend. There is truth and fiction woven into his identity. All of us, though, are unknowable, and we should be too easily discouraged from connecting with elements of Beethoven's life that may be difficult to prove.

Part of the legend of Beethoven is an attempt to justify music that carries such enormous weight. Some may detect that, in doing so, we lend the composer a superhuman-ness. But it is Beethoven's fallibility, weakness, alcoholism, passion, clumsiness, anger, joy, embarrassment, non-pretension, disability, expectation, rigor, pride, fondnesses, even fears, that place him in a tangible and very human way in our own world and minds as musicians. Our connection to the legend will decide how we imagine him, and what we imagine it meant to write this curiously unassuming yet temporally unfixed and enigmatic Bagatelle.

Imagination and empathy are a curious combination, yet inextricable. Applying them to a stylistic performance consideration is a uniquely self-illuminating process; it allows the performer to understand Beethoven through Beethoven's life as they've tried and come to know it— or, in other words, through themselves.